Three Mistakes Families Make When Sorting Out What's Wrong With a Parent's Care

Three habits to set down before the next family conversation, and what to pick up in their place.

When a parent's care starts slipping, caring families fall into the same three habits. They are easy to fall into, and each has a plain habit that replaces it.

1 Trying to solve every disagreement at once

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE One phone call is asked to cover the missed appointment, who visits more often, whether your father should move, and something that was said last Thanksgiving. An hour later nothing is settled and everyone is more tired.

WHY IT HAPPENS Everything feels connected, and getting the whole family on one call is hard, so the call gets asked to carry all of it. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one meeting, and that a narrow focus for each meeting helps. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Choose the concerns for the next conversation and put the rest on an open list, with the date beside each. The Family Caregiver Alliance's reminder is that a family meeting is not a one-time event, and that meeting regularly puts less pressure on everyone to get everything resolved in one. [1]

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2 Turning concerns into personal accusations

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “You never call him.” “You always take over.” “Nobody is looking after him properly.” The worry underneath is real. It arrives aimed at a person.

WHY IT HAPPENS Worry comes out fast when people are worn down. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that when we are tired and stressed, it is harder to stay in control of the things we say, and that guilt makes people uncomfortable and defensive. [2] [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Say what happened, with the day: “He missed his Tuesday appointment and no one knew until Thursday.” Then say what you need. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice is to focus just on the issue at hand, and to say “I need” where you were about to say “You should.” [3] [1]

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3 Overlooking the caregiver who is running out of capacity

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The family talks about your father's appointments, his meals and his house. The call ends before anyone gets around to asking your sister how her own week went, and when she is short on the phone it gets heard as attitude.

WHY IT HAPPENS The work arrived a little at a time, and from a distance it can look as if she has it covered. The Family Caregiver Alliance says siblings may assume exactly that, and so not recognize the added responsibilities. She may not say so herself: many caregivers are reluctant to ask for help. [3] [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her directly what cannot go on as it is, and write her answer down in her words. The National Institute on Aging's advice to anyone who isn't the primary caregiver is to ask what would be most helpful, and to acknowledge how important she is in your father's life. Then list what she does in a week, task by task, so the rest of the family can see it. [5]

What the three have in common

Each one trades something general for something specific: one topic for the call, one example for the complaint, one question for your sister. Specific things can be written down, and a written list is what the next conversation needs.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say who is right, whether your father is safe, or what your family should decide. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three habits to set down before the family talks again. The care interview gives you something to pick up in their place: a structured look at your father's situation, area by area, that turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The advice about family meetings, keeping to the issue at hand and asking the primary caregiver directly comes from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, The Emotional Side of Caregiving
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
5. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers

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